

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Italian Game

Quiet systems, open centers, gambits, structures, and modern plans

TRAINING WORKBOOK

30 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

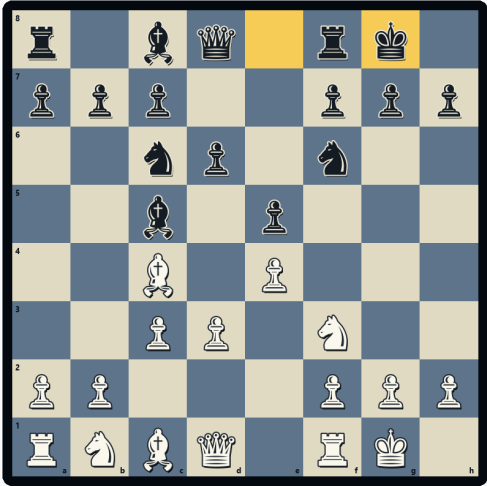
Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Giuoco Pianissimo c3-d3



02 - Giuoco Pianissimo

POSITION PROMPT

Both sides keep the center closed and improve pieces before deciding when d4 is favorable.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d3 d6 6. O-O O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

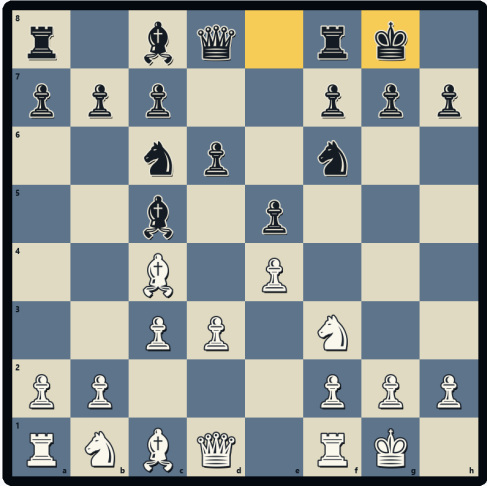
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Pianissimo 4.d3



02 - Giuoco Pianissimo

POSITION PROMPT

White commits to d3 before c3 and keeps the queenside knight flexible.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O d6 6. c3 O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Knight Maneuver Nbd2-f1-g3



02 - Giuoco Pianissimo

POSITION PROMPT

White reroutes the queen knight toward g3 while keeping c3 available for d4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d3 d6 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 a6 8. Nbd2 Ba7 9. Nf1

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
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5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Slow Italian with a4



02 - Giuoco Pianissimo

POSITION PROMPT

White restrains ...b5 and gains queenside space without opening the center.

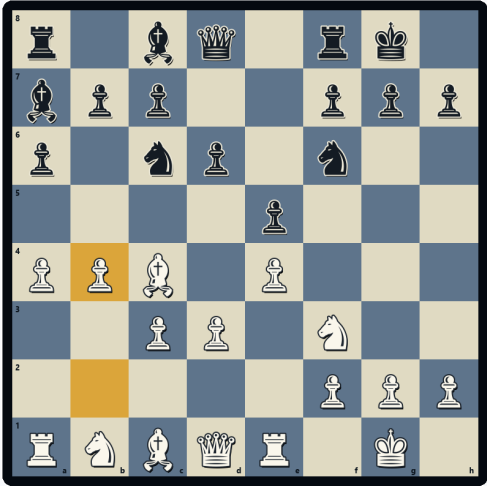
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. c3 d6 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 a6 8. a4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Slow Italian b4 Expansion



02 - Giuoco Pianissimo

POSITION PROMPT

White gains queenside space after restraining ...b5 and retreating Black's bishop.

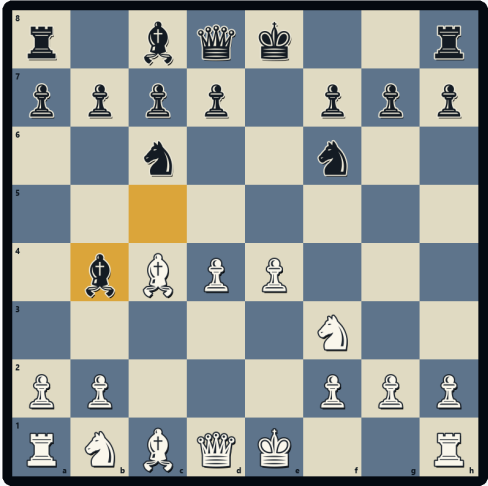
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. c3 d6 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 a6 8. a4 Ba7 9. b4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. Giuoco Piano Classical Center



03 - Classical Giuoco Piano

POSITION PROMPT

White builds the full c3-d4 center and Black immediately challenges it with check.

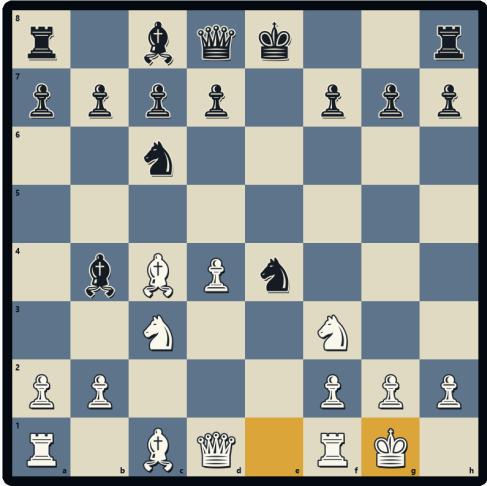
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb4+

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Classical Nc3 Main Line



03 - Classical Giuoco Piano

POSITION PROMPT

White accepts tactical pressure on e4 to accelerate development and central activity.

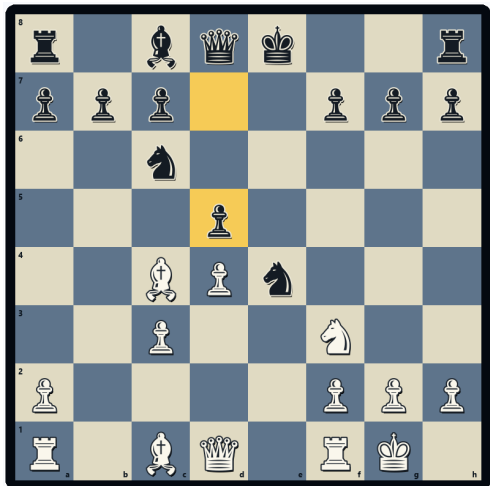
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb4+ 7. Nc3 Nxe4 8. O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Greco Attack



03 - Classical Giuoco Piano

POSITION PROMPT

Black damages White's structure to survive the central initiative and strike with ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb4+ 7. Nc3 Nxe4 8. O-O Bxc3 9. bxc3 d5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

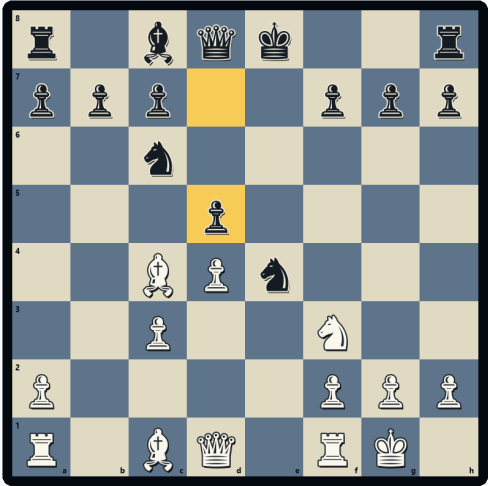
- ### 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Moeller Attack Decision Point



03 - Classical Giuoco Piano

POSITION PROMPT

White reaches the historic Moeller decision with open files, damaged pawns, and Black challenging the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb4+ 7. Nc3 Nxe4 8. O-O Bxc3 9. bxc3 d5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

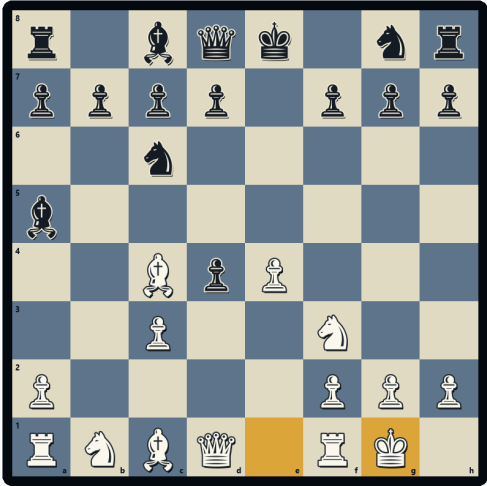
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Evans Gambit Accepted



04 - Evans Gambit

POSITION PROMPT

White gives the b-pawn to gain c3 and d4 with tempo against the bishop.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. b4 Bxb4 5. c3 Ba5 6. d4 exd4 7. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

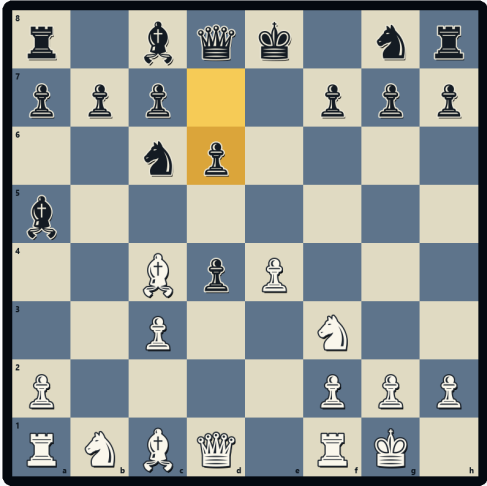
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Evans Main Line with ...Ba5



04 - Evans Gambit

POSITION PROMPT

Black chooses the traditional retreat and builds a defensive center with ...d6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. b4 Bxb4 5. c3 Ba5 6. d4 exd4 7. O-O d6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

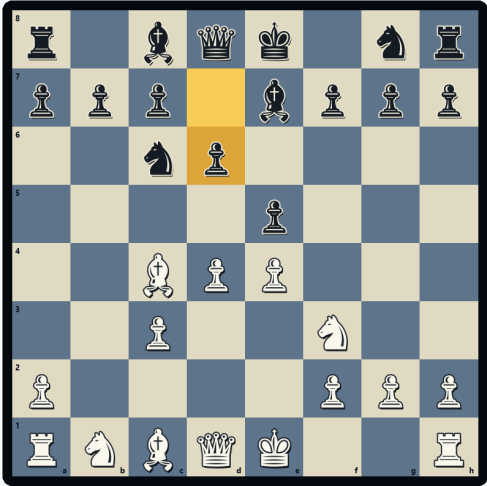
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Evans Compromised Defense



04 - Evans Gambit

POSITION PROMPT

Black returns the bishop to e7 and gives up some activity to reduce forcing lines.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. b4 Bxb4 5. c3 Be7 6. d4 d6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

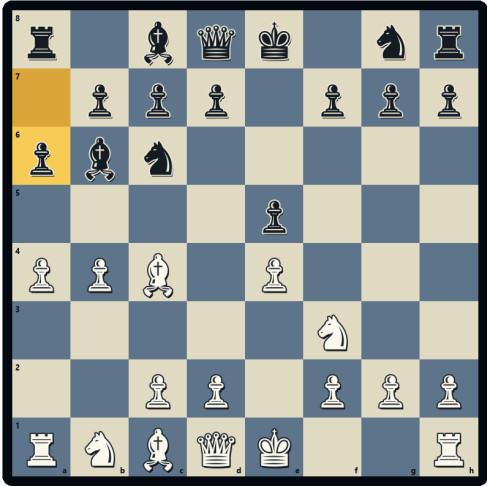
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Evans Gambit Declined



04 - Evans Gambit

POSITION PROMPT

Black refuses the pawn and keeps a sound structure while White gains queenside space.

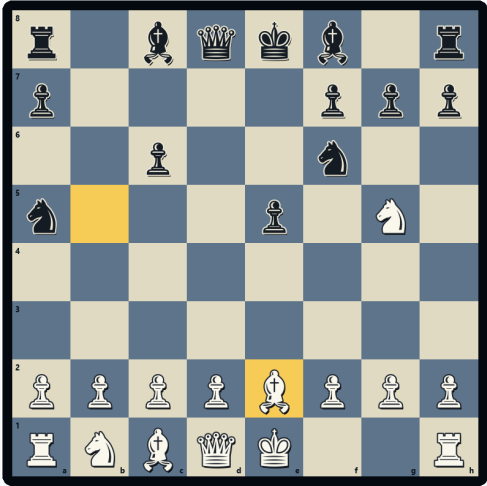
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. b4 Bb6 5. a4 a6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Two Knights Main Line



05 - Two Knights Defense

POSITION PROMPT

Black sacrifices or delays a pawn to gain tempi against the c4-bishop and open central lines.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nf6 4. Ng5 d5 5. exd5 Na5 6. Bb5+ c6 7. dxc6 bxc6 8. Be2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

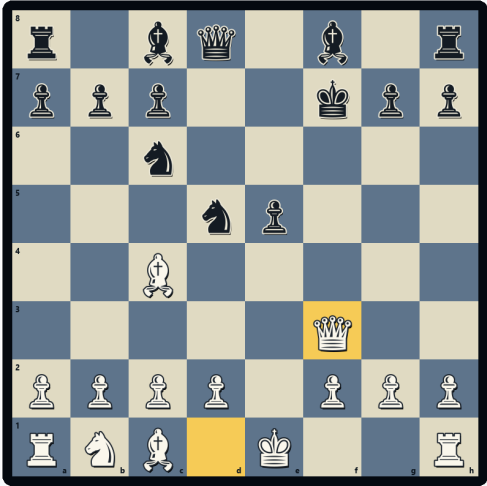
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Fried Liver Attack



05 - Two Knights Defense

POSITION PROMPT

White sacrifices a knight on f7 to expose the king after Black's risky ...Nxd5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nf6 4. Ng5 d5 5. exd5 Nxd5 6. Nxf7 Kxf7 7. Qf3+

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

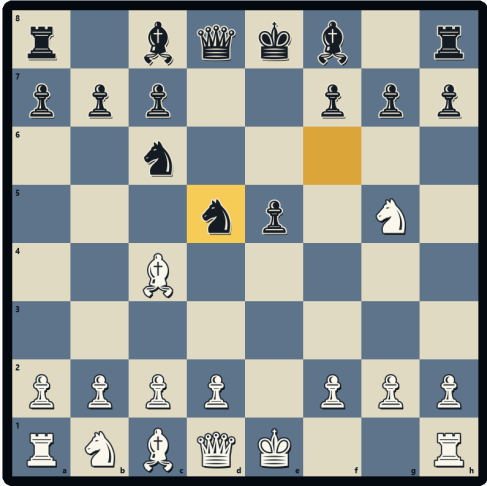
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Lolli Attack Decision Point



05 - Two Knights Defense

POSITION PROMPT

White reaches the critical choice between the forcing Nxf7 sacrifice and the quieter historic d4 approach.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nf6 4. Ng5 d5 5. exd5 Nxd5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

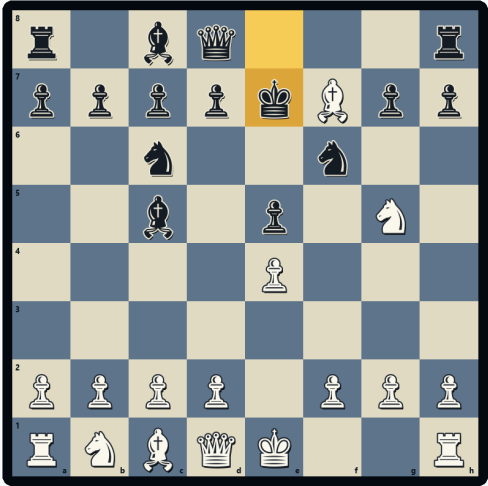
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Traxler Counterattack



05 - Two Knights Defense

POSITION PROMPT

Black ignores f7 and creates immediate threats against White's king and f2.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nf6 4. Ng5 Bc5 5. Bxf7+ Ke7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

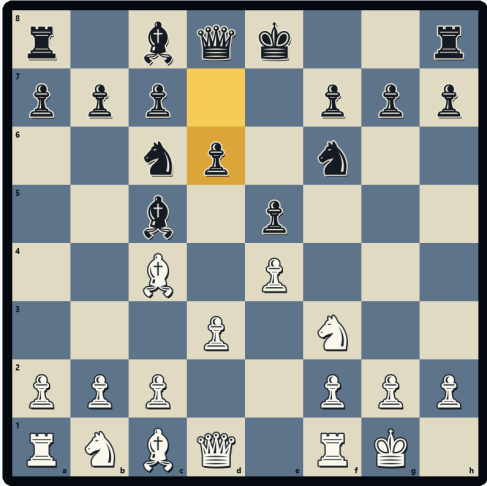
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Two Knights 4.d3



05 - Two Knights Defense

POSITION PROMPT

White avoids the forcing Ng5 theory and enters a quiet Italian structure.

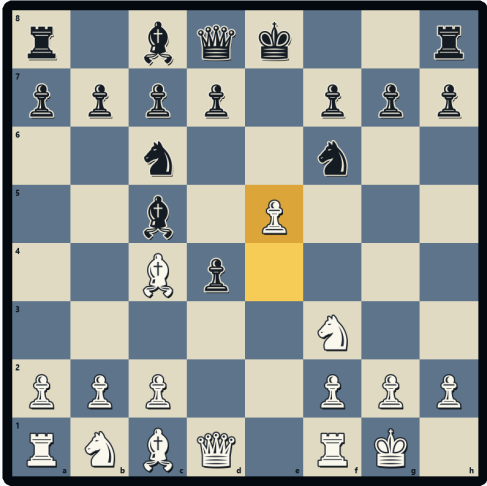
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nf6 4. d3 Bc5 5. O-O d6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Max Lange Attack



06 - Italian Gambit Complexes

POSITION PROMPT

White advances e5 to attack the f6-knight while the center and e-file open.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. O-O Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

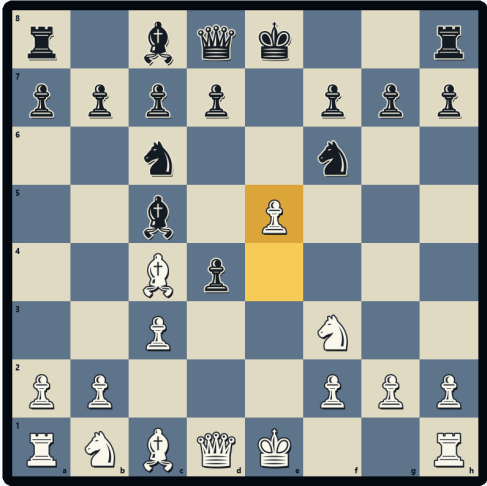
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Scotch Gambit Transposition



06 - Italian Gambit Complexes

POSITION PROMPT

White uses c3 and e5 to enter a Scotch-Gambit-style center with the bishop on c4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. e5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

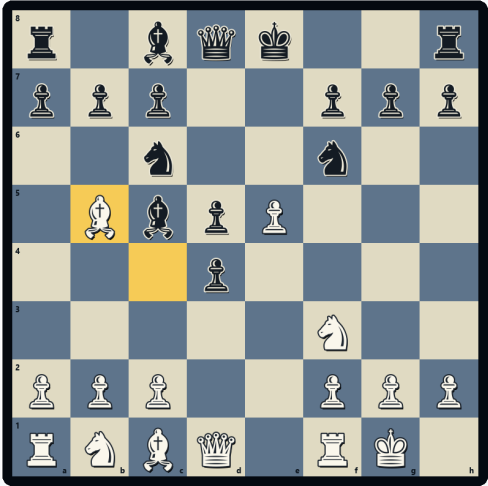
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

21. Deutz Gambit



06 - Italian Gambit Complexes

POSITION PROMPT

White offers central material for rapid pressure while Black counters with ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. O-O Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. e5 d5 7. Bb5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

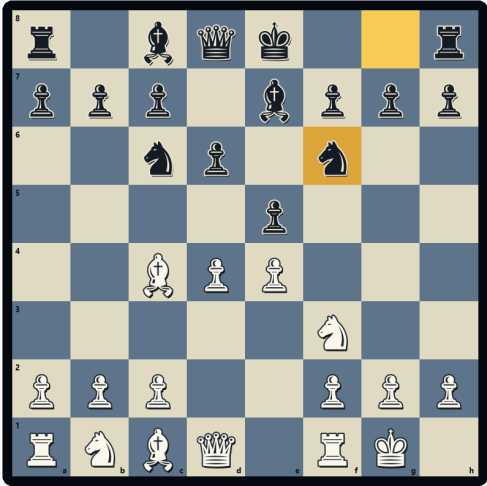
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

22. Hungarian Defense



07 - Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black adopts a compact setup that reduces direct tactics on f7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Be7 4. d4 d6 5. O-O Nf6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

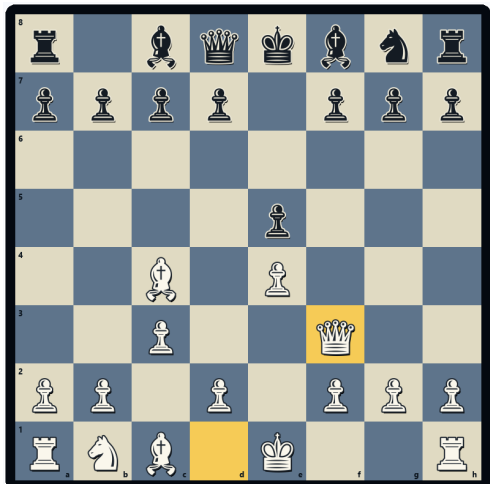
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

23. Blackburne Shilling Gambit



07 - Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black offers e5 and threatens tactical attacks on g2 and e5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nd4 4. c3 Nxf3+ 5. Qxf3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

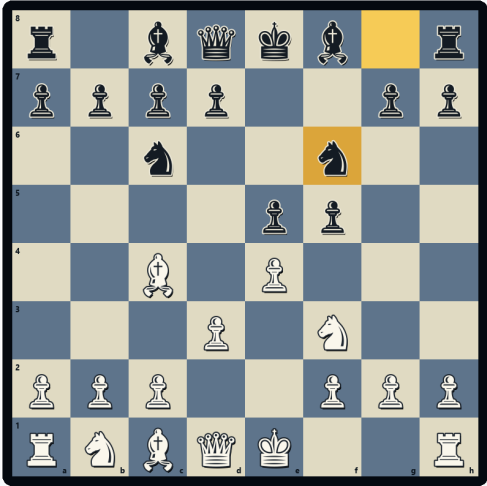
- ### 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

24. Rousseau Gambit



07 - Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black uses an early ...f5 to seize space and create a reversed King's Gambit structure.

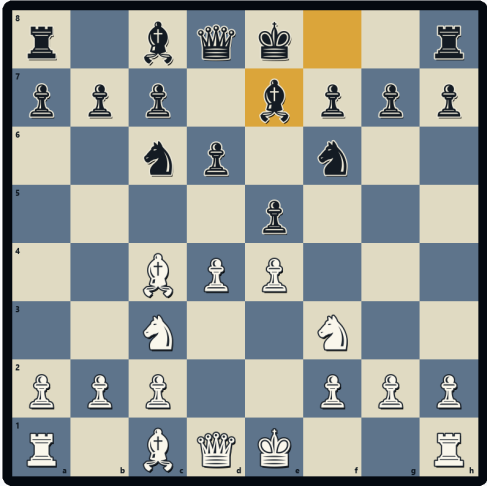
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 f5 4. d3 Nf6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

25. Italian with 3...d6



07 - Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black reinforces e5 and enters a Philidor-like Italian without developing the f8-bishop actively.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 d6 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Be7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

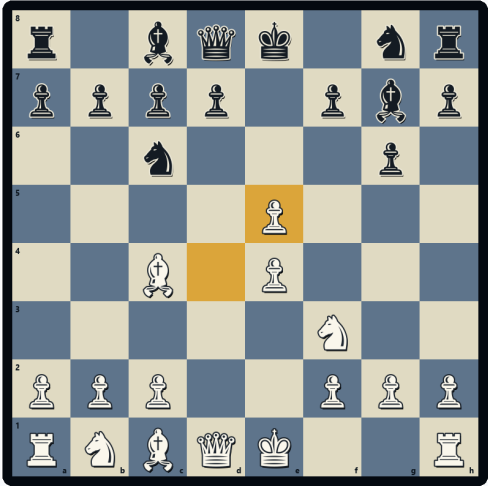
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

26. Italian with 3...g6



07 - Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black fianchettoes and delays kingside development pressure on e4.

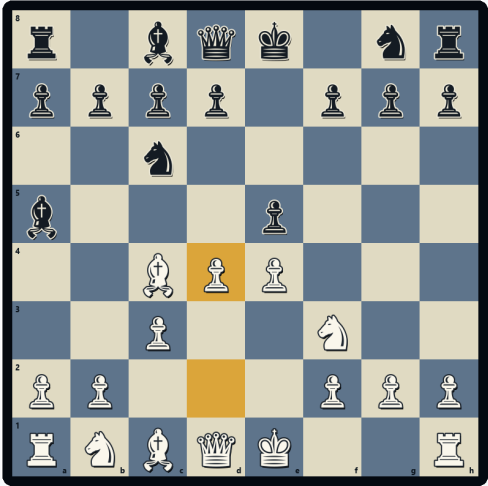
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 g6 4. d4 Bg7 5. dxe5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

27. Italian with 3...Bb4



07 - Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black pins or checks indirectly from b4 and invites White to gain a center with tempo.

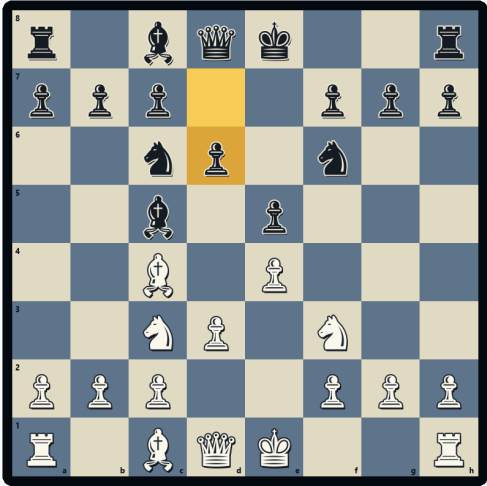
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bb4 4. c3 Ba5 5. d4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

28. Italian Four Knights



08 - Structures and Repertoire Choices

POSITION PROMPT

White develops the queen knight early and accepts that c3 is no longer available.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. Nc3 Nf6 5. d3 d6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

29. Slow Italian Re1-a4



08 - Structures and Repertoire Choices

POSITION PROMPT

White combines central support with queenside restraint before the knight maneuver.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. c3 d6 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 a6 8. a4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

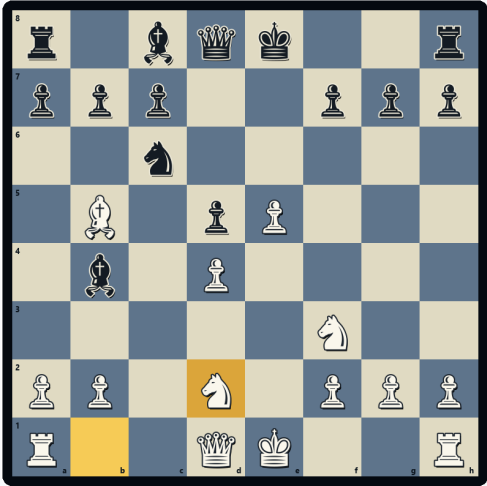
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

30. Central Liquidation



08 - Structures and Repertoire Choices

POSITION PROMPT

A forcing central sequence trades tension for an imbalanced minor-piece and pawn structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. e5 d5 7. Bb5 Ne4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Nxd2 10. Nbx d2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.